May 11, 2023

Cailin Hoang

Personal Statement: My family consists of generations of Chinese-Vietnamese medicine doctors. My aunt, now a licensed acupuncturist, often recounts the times she witnessed my grandfather treating patients on the jungle floor when they were refugees. I took great inspiration in Traditional Vietnamese Medicine (TVM), and its sensation-central nature. I grew up shadowing my aunt, learning how to palpate the dense feeling of injured muscle tissue, and evaluate circulation competency in limbs. As a pre-med student, I am really interested in integrative medicine, and how it supplements the targeted methodologies of allopathic medicine with the macroscopic, pain management oriented methodologies of traditional medicine.

Reference from Kenneth Nelson, faculty at Yale University:

My interactions with Cailin Hoang have principally been through the Yale STARS Program. The STARS program is designed to help retain women and minority students in the science majors at Yale, and I am the academic director for this program.
In 2022, Cailin participated in the STARS Summer Program which includes 9 weeks of research in a faculty lab and included presentation of the research results in a paper and in a talk at a STARS student symposium. Cailin did most of her research in the lab of Dr. Ajona Megalathan in the Yale Chemistry Department. Cailin was a standout student, and I recall that her project involved studying the RNA phase separations in variying salt concentrations. Along with the research component of the STARS Summer Program, there is a daily course that focuses on communication skillls, and I I teach that course.
Cailin had just finished her first year at Yale and had never done any laboratory research, and she was not even sure of which major she would choose. However, she enthusiastically jumped into her research project and did excellent work. She became fully engaged and she became very possessive of the project. It was hers. At the end of the summer when all of the students presented their research results, Cailin's paper required very little editing and her symposium presentation was polished. Her symposium presentation was the quality of an advanced graduate student rather than an undergrad. Therefore, her communication skills are very good. She got along very well with the other 28 students in the summer program and became one of the family with them.
After her summer in the STARS program, Cailin has was so enthusiastic about her first research experience that she continued to do research, and is interested in expanding her experiences in biomedical research. To that end, Cailin is applying to summer research abroad to expand her knowledge of traditinoal medicines. She is strongly considering a career in medicine. She has the talent and drive to thrive in medical school, and she has the personal skills to contribute to a community of scholars. As a participant in a overseas program, Cailin will be a good ambassador for science, medicin , and the U.S.
In short, Cailin Hoang is intelligent, has a good work ethic, communicates well, and has a pleasant and outgoing personality. She has the talent and focus to become a cometent and caring physician. I can recommend her highly for acceptance in the SIT Study Abroad Program.

Katherine Nguyen

School for International Training
1 Kipling Road, PO Box 676
Brattleboro, VT 05302-0676 USA
P: 802 258-3112
F: 802 258-3110
studyabroad@sit.edu
studyabroad.sit.edu

Personal Statement: As an exercise and sport science major and health and society and sports medicine minor, I am interested in learning about how the human body functions and treating injuries through stretches exercises, and more holistic approaches. Hearing stories from family members about their struggles living in Vietnam to even feed themselves sufficiently inspired me to learn more about how I can use my education to bring equal access to a healthy lifestyle. I am a Vietnamese growing up in America. My family's identity as Vietnamese influenced the traditions we practiced, the holidays celebrated, and the dishes we ate. I also value devoting time to serving others through my extracurricular clubs.

Reference from Matthew Hartshorne, Teaching Assistant at the University of North Carolina Chapel Hill

Intellectual and other strengths
Katherine performed very well in Human Physiology. Human Physiology is a tough, fast paced course that requires critical thinking about how complex processes work throughout the human body and then apply them to real-life scenarios. Katherine demonstrated her resilience and determination by creating structure learning activities to absorb the information presented in the lecture and recall material on the various systems of the body. Additionally, she visited office hours among the professor and teaching assistants to get any of her questions answered and master the material. This shows that she is committed to her own learning. If she does not understand a concept presented in a lecture, she will take the time to visit office hours or attend review sessions before the exam. This passion for learning will be relevant to her study abroad experience because she will be able to take the information learned through lectures and assignments into real-world excursions. The lessons that Katherine will learn in your program will carry on into her own identity as a Vietnamese woman and career of athletic training using exercise as medicine.

Another strength of Katherine is her ability to lead and work collaboratively with others to execute tasks in a group setting. All of our data research sessions were in a group setting where students were placed in small groups to learn how to use lab equipment and collect data. Katherine demonstrated her leadership by volunteering to teach other students how to use different laboratory equipment and provided and accepted constructive peer feedback to accomplish the objectives of the sessions. Much of the learning in the laboratory sessions were through trial and error. While others demonstrated frustration with this technique, Katherine took it on as a challenge and stood out amongst the other students with her determination and grit. This will be relevant to her study abroad experience because this study abroad opportunity has the same collaborative group environment. Katherine will excel in working in a group environment with the common goal of learning more about Vietnamese traditional medicine and health practices. She can contribute her own strength of curiosity and collaboration with other students and advisors to make the most out of this learning experience.
Intellectual and other weaknesses
Katherine’s weakness of not having the largest knowledge about medical practices will be relevant to studying abroad. Katherine aspires to become an athletic trainer to help athletes fully recover and return to sport without limitations. While she has limited experience and understanding about the medical practices and treatment plans that are provided, with her passion and eagerness for learning she will benefit tremendously from this experience. As she advances through her courses and spends more hours shadowing at the athletic training facility on campus, she will become more familiar with the different treatment plans for injuries, modalities, and exercises for rehabilitation and recovery.

This will be relevant to studying abroad because she can take what she learned about traditional medicine evolved from China and Vietnam and connect that knowledge with how American medical practices evolved from Western traditions, thus creating a more multidimensional view of healthcare and approaches and making her a more well-rounded athletic trainer.

Motivation, ability, and maturity

I believe Katherine's motivation to learn and apply the information to her career will make her successful when studying abroad. She has the full ability and maturity to be successful in the goals she has set for herself with studying abroad. I believe she has the capacity to achieve her main goal of learning and appreciating the differences in medical practices/approaches. She is the type of individual who has the drive and motivation to accomplish any goal she sets and the grit to see things through to the end. I have no doubt that she will put her full effort into immersing herself in the Vietnamese culture, lifestyle, and education. Besides her academic goals of learning more about medical practices, I believe she will unquestionably achieve her goal of learning more about Vietnamese culture, language, and traditions. There is no better way to learn than to experience it first-hand. Katherine comes to class ready to learn and engage with the material. With the same motivation she presents in class, she will be an interactive student studying abroad achieving her goal of learning about Vietnamese medicine and culture.

Additional Comments

Katherine is an honest, passionate, caring, driven, and incredibly hard-working individual. I have no reservations recommending Katherine to join the SIT Study Abroad Program. I believe her strong work ethic, persistence, eagerness to learn, character, and professional attributes make her a strong candidate for your program. Furthermore, I believe that SIT Study Abroad faculty, staff, and students who would work closely with Katherine would find a rewarding, collaborative atmosphere within their interactions.

Lusangelis Ramos

Personal Statement: I am a Venezuelan immigrant and I have lived in New York for most of my life. I am deeply interested in how public health policies can improve the health of marginalized communities that have been neglected for centuries by the academic science and healthcare fields. I like exploring different fields and areas of interest since I believe in multidisciplinary ways to solve all types of problems. I hope to one day travel all around the world to do research and collaborate with a diverse team of experts that are dedicated to making sure people everywhere have the right to health.

Reference from Ximena Lopez Carillo, Lecturer at Yale University

Intellectual and other strengths

Since the beginning of the semester, Lusangelis was a very diligent, thorough, and responsible student who submitted her weekly assignments on time with the highest academic standards. Every week, Lusangelis demonstrated an excellent command of the readings and knew how to connect the theoretical discussions with practical concerns about improving the Latine community's access to healthcare and to information that would help them to take control of their well-being proactively and holistically. Their attitude in class was always very collegial and vibrant. They were always one of the first students to break the

ice by asking incisive questions about the readings and by sharing with the class their own observations about the Venezuelan community in the United States. But while a talkative student, Lusangelis was also a careful and respectful listener who engaged with their classmates. They were confident, independent, amicable, and mature, all of which are qualities that would make Lusangelis a great addition to the Study Abroad group. In each class, I was always grateful to have a student who contributed so much to the creation of a lively and collaborative environment.Edit Intellectual and other strengths
Intellectual and other weaknesses
I consider that Lusangelis' biggest challenge during the study abroad would be to become comfortable with her Chinese language skills. Since I met them, they had already a grasp of the language and continued to study and look for opportunities to practice it. However, they might encounter that speaking the language in an informal setting is different than in a classroom.

Knowing how persistent Lusangelis is, I am confident that, once they are able to get comfortable with the language, they will become the participative and lively student I met in my class.Edit Intellectual and other weaknesses
Motivation, ability, and maturity
During my course, Lusangelis demonstrated great interest in the use of traditional practices among the Latine community. For two weeks, we discussed the important role it has played in providing healthcare to an underserved Latine community, strengthening cultural and community ties, and preserving ancestral worldviews that do not always align with mainstream American culture. By looking at the use of peyote by Native American communities in the US-Mexico borderland and midwifery in New Mexico, the class identified the elements that make these practices so persistent despite their racialization and marginalization by the American healthcare system.

Lusangelis was very interested in this topic, especially because her final project researched the alliances between the Cuban and the Venezuelan government to develop a health program called Barrio Adentro. Lusangelis wrote that, while Barrio Adentro was guided by the ideal of providing holistic healthcare accessible to everyone (including those in the periphery) it ultimately failed due to ideological disputes, financial and operational challenges, and Venezuela's political instability. Although her paper could not expand on this topic due to the lack of primary sources, she opened the important question of how the local healing knowledge and traditions could have helped to advance the progressive goals of Barrio Adentro. I consider that her experience in this program would help her to answer those unresolved questions and to understand traditional medicine from a practical, more than a theoretical, perspective. This is especially because the Cuban medical programs that informed Barrio Adentro were in turn inspired by the Third World ideology (of which Vietnam was part of) and China's Barefoot Doctors program (which revitalized local healing traditions as a way to expand healthcare access). This trip would allow her to understand the intricacies of traditional medicine and medical pluralism in a historically significant place such as Vietnam.Edit Motivation, ability, and maturity
Additional Comments

I am certain that, if accepted into the study abroad, Lusangelis would take full advantage of the opportunity, and would contribute to the program with passion, collegiality, and a desire to learn and interact with their classmates. I can only add that it has been a privilege to have Lusangelis as a student and I am happy to answer any additional questions you may have about their character and their work in my class.

Sadie Nichols

Personal Statement: I come from a rural, close knit, West Virginia town called Sistersville, and in which my parents, two younger brothers, and cats reside. I have lived there my entire life until college at West Virginia Wesleyan College. Both of my parents are local family practice physicians, which sparked in me my own desire to pursue medicine. I love to read, sing, hike, and travel. At college, I am in the concert chorale, president of the Student Senate, and work with special education children in an elementary school. I hope to pursue medicine and go on to medical school after undergraduate.

Reference from Jessica Vincent, Director of Community Engagement at West Virginia Wesleyan College

Intellectual and other strengths
When Sadie came to campus as a first-year student, she connected with a special education classroom at a rural elementary school. In our county, 54% of the students go home to a nontraditional household. Many students are raised by grandparents, and an alarming number of students come to school without their basic needs of food, shelter, and safety met. Sadie was a true mentor to the students in her class. She instilled in the children that they could reach their potential and that science was exciting. Sadie would frequently spend one-on-one time with students who were nonverbal or experienced unique medical and learning challenges. The teacher described the days when Sadie was in her classroom as a breath of fresh air where even the most challenging students gave their all simply because of her presence. You could see her knowledge from her classes guiding her through thoughtful conversations full of positivity. She worked to achieve common ground with each student and assumed the relationship's vulnerabilities to ensure the student felt understood and confident. This example is a snapshot of how Sadie chooses to live out the Student Leadership Challenge in which she models the way, inspires a shared vision, enables others to act, challenges the process, and encourages the heart.

Sadie is a relationship builder and strategic thinker by nature. He dedicates all that he has to give and more to his commitments. We work directly with over 100 students. Of those students, I selected Sadie as an orientation leader for the new students entering our program. On this trip to a rural community with no cell phone service and an aging population of 52 people, Sadie led a group of students in removing literal tons of broken-down mulch and weeds from an elementary school playground. Despite being a scorching hot day, Sadie was positive and encouraging to her peers. When challenges arose, she creatively thought of ways to make the activity fun and systematic. Her solution brought efficiency to the team, while his engaging personality made hard, tiring work feel like a fun competition. I've seen this same dedication and engagement from Sadie as a research student, Student Senate President, and sorority officer on campus. The quality of her work is top-

notch, and she puts in the extra steps to ensure a meaningful experience for all involved. She is the bridge that leads people to a place of safety and belonging, no matter their differences.
Intellectual and other weaknesses
Sadie is the type of student whose commitment is like an overflowing well. She gives so much that she forgets to take time for herself. I can imagine this trait will only increase when there is a timeframe involved. Despite these challenges, she does know how to ask for help and will accept support when offered.
Motivation, ability, and maturity
Sadie is someone whose excitement can be easily felt by every person in the room. Even the thought of this opportunity sent Sadie down a path of research. She was quickly equipped with facts and could articulate challenges she may experience. She sat out on a plan to learn more and overcome challenges, so she would be fully prepared and invested if the opportunity were presented.

I truly see Sadie as someone who will dedicate her life's work to traveling abroad and giving medical access to underserved communities. She has the willpower. She is committed to being a lifelong learner. Most importantly, her heart and mind are always headed in the same direction.

A student who spends time developing their leadership skills and devoting time to others is the type of leader I want to see excelling in the medical field. I am confident in Sadie's ability to advance his goal from moving hills to moving mountains if provided with this new and exciting opportunity. Furthermore, if you invest in Sadie now, she will pass it on to someone else in the future.
Additional Comments
I give my highest recommendation to Sadie and sincere appreciation to you for considering one of Wesleyan's finest.

Samantha Pohly

Personal Statement: I grew up in lower Manhattan with my parents, sister, and of course, my dog and two cats. New York City’s dynamism has provided me with day-to-day learning experiences in unexpected places and has encouraged me to pursue a variety of passions. From a young age, I have nurtured a love for music and theater, which I have continued to pursue at Yale by singing with an a capella group and performing in various theatrical productions. On a different note, I am deeply passionate about medicine, healthcare, and reproductive justice and plan to pursue a career as an OBGYN.

Reference from Claudia Valeggia, professor at Yale University

Intellectual and other strengths
Strengths: Samantha is a brilliant and thoughtful student, she has an outstanding sense of the "big picture" in her discussions and is able to move fast among different learning media. The most relevant of her qualities for studying abroad is her abstolute passion for learning and appreciating cultural and societal variation in approaches to health care. This passion is carefully cultivated and rests on a good deal of common sense, respect, and ability to learn from others. I have no doubts she will shine in an international living experience and will contribute greatly to it.
Intellectual and other weaknesses

Weaknesses: After having interacting with Samantha over one semester, it is hard for me to point to any particular weakness that would make you decide not to take invite her to join your program abroad. I apologize for not being able to help you in this regard.
Motivation, ability, and maturity
As I mentioned before, Samantha's motivation levels to learn from other cultures is simply outstanding. She was the student who showed the most interest in learning from my research in Argentina and the co-instructor 's study of maternal health in Samoa. She was constantly asking thoughtful questions about cultural variation and how the US maternal healthcare system can learn from other approaches. Her comments were always respectful and she has shown a remarkable level of maturity in the classroom. I can definitely see this same drive continuing in an international setting
Additional Comments
Offer Samantha admission to your program! You will not regret it. She works well both in groups and independently and she is an absolute pleasure to be around. Her smile and compassionate demeanor brightens any place she goes.

Truc-Linh Dam

Personal Statement: I'm a second generation Vietnamese American who deeply values the closeness of my family. Care is at the forefront of everything we do. My mother's health-conscientious practices have influenced my passion for wellness, which I explore through movement and track and field. As an injury-prone athlete, I would research preventative measures, combining the patterns of what I'd read with information from physical therapists and the school trainer. It's through sports that I found one of my communities and some of my closest friends. My roots are an ocean away, but the track is the closest thing to home I know.

Reference from Eric Russel, professor at the University of California, Davis

Truc-Lihn was a student in my HUM 15 course (Language and Identity). Writing ability: excellent, Ability to express themselves orally: good, Initiative: excellent, Ability to work with a group of peers: good, Ability to cope with ambiguity: good. They speak Vietnamese already and have an excellent command of English, along with basic knowledge of Spanish. This gives Truc-Linh a leg up in being able to interact across cultural boundaries, as well as a heightened ability to see the world and others through plural lenses.